> Everyone pretends to be happy online, it's almost like a contest. **There's no need for positivity anymore, anyone doing it is copying millions.** It is too overdone
>
> **-SUNAINA REKHI**
> *Lifestyle Influencer*



MANDAR DEODHAR

Shreyasi Walia, 30, a spiritual influencer from Bengaluru. "To get noticed online, I had to be relatable." Walia began making videos on the benefits of meditation. "I saw so much anxiety, jealousy and anger around me. I knew there was space for something positive to be done." Walia has now totted up more than 11,000 followers on Instagram.

THE BUSINESS OF SPIRITUALITY

Market research firm IMARC Group estimates the Indian religious/ spiritual market in India was worth $54.1 billion (Rs 44,000 crore) in 2022 and expects it to touch $97.2 billion (Rs 80,000 crore) by 2028. And spiritualists who hit the big league enjoy a hefty slice of this pie. An Instagram influencer who has around 450,000 followers and who does not wish to be named confesses that she gets weekly offers to endorse spiritual brands and wellness retreats. Some are as high as Rs 3 lakh for a video, with the condition that 50 per cent will be given only if it gains 10,000 plus likes. "I don't want to compromise on my ethics, so I need to pick the right partnerships," she says. There is also the stress of ensuring a video goes viral. "I have stopped accepting offers with conditions as it gives me huge stress. Businesses are brutal about deals with influencers; it doesn't matter if it is selling t-shirts or inner peace," she adds.

Why, there are even online courses now on how to run a spiritual business. Udemy's 'Become a Master Influencer with Spirituality' course, for instance has a 4.7 rating and nearly 1,700 students. It teaches one to identify an audi-ence, convert followers into paying clients and transform the way followers connect with your content.

Making money from spirituality is an ethical dilemma influencers face. "Considering most spiritual discourses are rooted in the idea of shunning materialism, I think paid partnerships could end up diluting one's very purpose," says Walia, who does not wish to monetise her popularity. "I do it because I want to leave a positive mark," she says.

Like paid partnerships, digital spirituality has other aspects that are at odds with traditional spiritualism. While talking about freeing oneself from material bonds, it also celebrates self-help and practicality. Naturally, its pre-cepts are fluid, with little pressure to strictly adhere to any rule. Moreover, each influencer is free to chart her own path. Shani Dayal, 35, an architect and wellness coach from Gurugram, has 112,000 Instagram followers who love her videos on yoga and meditation. For Dayal, spirituality is staying true to the practice of yoga and meditation. "I believe teaching to be my dharma.... We are all spiritual at our source, you and me, we just don't know it because we have lost that connect. Yoga helps to bring this connect back," says she.

For 'emotional influencer' Divija Bhasin, 26, from Delhi, it's the life around her that inspires her content. "I decide topics based on mes-sages from followers," she says. "I also get ideas from music and movies." Topics related to gender, parenting, sexual abuse and the education system get the most positive feedback. "I receive messages from followers, saying my content makes them feel less lonely," says Bhasin, who has 188,000 followers on Instagram. Sadhguru, whose connect with followers is well-known, is inimitably relatable. "I give them a better alternative to philosophy. I say, if you look at my eyes, I am always stoned. There's no need to buy anything.... You can sit here and get knocked out. The greatest chemical factory on the planet is the human body. If I teach you a way where you can be blissed out, would you be interested? Every youth is interested," he explains.

That said, the multitude of spiritual routes, all deemed equally valid, to